



FAILURE & REJECTION

WHEN THINGS DON'T GO THE WAY YOU HOPED

Understanding disappointment, rebuilding confidence, and moving forward.



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Failure can feel personal. A rejected application, an unsuccessful exam, a missed opportunity, a friendship that changed, or a goal that did not work out can leave students wondering whether they are good enough. But an outcome is not the same thing as your identity. Failure and rejection are experiences—not permanent definitions of who you are.

WHY DOES FAILURE HURT SO MUCH?

Students often connect achievement with identity. When something goes wrong, it can feel as though the setback says something about their worth. Academic pressure, comparison with peers, family expectations, financial stress, and uncertainty about the future can make disappointment feel heavier.

It is possible to take a setback seriously without treating it as proof that you are incapable.

THOUGHTS TO WATCH FOR

- “I failed, so I am a failure.”
- “Everyone else is moving ahead.”
- “I should have got it right the first time.”
- “If they rejected me, I must not be good enough.”

“A setback can change your direction without deciding your destination.”

02

FAILURE IS INFORMATION, NOT A VERDICT

When something does not work, the first reaction may be disappointment, embarrassment, anger, or self-doubt. Give yourself room to acknowledge those feelings. Then ask a different question: **What can this experience teach me?**

01

SEPARATE THE EVENT FROM YOUR IDENTITY

"I was rejected" describes an event. "I am not good enough" is a conclusion. They are not the same statement.

02

LOOK AT WHAT YOU CAN LEARN

Review what happened honestly. Was there a skill you need to strengthen, information you lacked, timing that was difficult, or something outside your control?

03

ALLOW YOURSELF TO FEEL DISAPPOINTED

You do not have to pretend that rejection does not hurt. Acknowledging disappointment can be healthier than hiding it or immediately blaming yourself.

04

TRY AGAIN—OR TRY DIFFERENTLY

Sometimes the next step is another attempt. Sometimes it is a new strategy, a different opportunity, or a revised goal. Moving forward does not have to mean repeating the same approach.

A HEALTHIER WAY TO TALK TO YOURSELF

Instead of...	Try...
"I always mess things up."	"This did not go as planned. What can I change next time?"
"They rejected me because I am not good enough."	"This opportunity did not work out. I can keep developing and applying."
"Everyone is ahead of me."	"People have different timelines. I can focus on my next step."

03

5 WAYS TO HANDLE FAILURE & REJECTION

Small, practical responses can help you recover your perspective and keep moving.

01

PAUSE BEFORE JUDGING YOURSELF

Give yourself time to process what happened before making big conclusions about your future.

02

NAME WHAT HAPPENED

Be specific. "My application was unsuccessful" is more useful than "I am useless." Specific language makes problem-solving possible.

03

LOOK FOR THE NEXT SMALL STEP

Choose one action you can take: ask for feedback, revise your CV, study a topic, practise a skill, or identify another opportunity.

04

TALK TO SOMEONE YOU TRUST

A supportive friend, mentor, lecturer, family member, counsellor, or other trusted person can help you see the situation from another angle.

05

KEEP YOUR FUTURE BIGGER THAN ONE OUTCOME

One result cannot contain your whole story. Keep learning, exploring opportunities, and adjusting your plans when necessary.

Remember: resilience does not mean never feeling disappointed. It means finding a way to respond, learn, and continue.

04

WHEN REJECTION STARTS AFFECTING YOUR WELL-BEING

Repeated setbacks can sometimes affect confidence, concentration, motivation, relationships, or daily routines. If disappointment is becoming difficult to manage, reaching out for support is a reasonable step—not a sign that you have failed.

CHECK IN WITH YOURSELF	ASK FOR SUPPORT
Notice changes in your mood, sleep, concentration, motivation, or ability to enjoy everyday activities.	Talk with someone you trust or a qualified support person when you feel you are struggling to cope.
RETURN TO BASICS	REDUCE COMPARISON
Keep a manageable routine around rest, meals, study/work, movement, and connection with others.	Social media and peer comparison can make setbacks feel larger. Give yourself permission to focus on your own progress.

A SIMPLE REFLECTION

What happened?	What was within my control?	What is my next step?

“You can be disappointed by an outcome and still believe in your ability to grow.”

05

YOUR STORY IS BIGGER THAN ONE SETBACK

A closing message from Community of Care Initiative

There may be moments when rejection makes you question your abilities or failure makes you want to stop trying. Be gentle with yourself in those moments. You are allowed to learn slowly, change direction, ask for help, and begin again.

Your path through university and early adulthood will not always be predictable. Some doors will close. Some plans will change. Some opportunities will arrive later than you expected. None of those experiences has to become the final sentence of your story.

Learn from what happened. Keep what is useful. Release what is not. Then take the next step.

***FAILURE IS AN EXPERIENCE.
REJECTION IS AN OUTCOME.***

NEITHER ONE DEFINES YOUR WORTH.

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